

FIFA World Cup 2026 Tracker

Project Documentation

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1. What Is This Program?

This is a Python program that lets you track the complete 2026 FIFA World Cup — from the group stage all the way through the knockout rounds to the final and World Cup winner. You run it in the terminal on your computer and interact with it through a simple numbered menu.

For completeness it needs to be mentioned that the program was developed with the assistance of Claude.

2. 2026 World Cup Format — Rules Explained

Group Stage

- 48 teams divided into 12 groups of 4 (Groups A to L).
- Each team plays the other 3 teams once, so 6 matches per group, 72 in total.
- Win = 3 points, Draw = 1 point each, Loss = 0 points.
- Ranked by: points, goal difference and then goals scored.

Who Qualifies for the Knockout Stage?

- Top 2 from each group qualify automatically: 24 teams
- Best 8 third-place teams from all 12 groups also qualify: 32 teams in total
- 4th-place teams eliminated (12 teams) and the 4 worst third-place teams as well

The 8 best third-place teams are found by ranking all 12 third-place teams together by points, then goal difference, then goals scored (as above).

Knockout Stage

- Round of 32 (32 teams) → Round of 16 (16 teams) → Quarterfinals (8 teams) → Semifinals (4 teams) → Final (2 teams) → World Cup Winner
- No draws in knockout matches. If tied after 90 minutes, extra time then penalties decide
- In this program you pick the winner or simulate randomly, no need to enter scores

3. What Can the Program Do?

The program has 9 features accessible from a numbered main menu:

1. View All Groups and Teams

Shows all 12 official 2026 World Cup groups with their 4 teams each.

2. Enter Match Results

Select a group from a numbered list. The program shows all pre-scheduled matches for that group. Pick a match by number and enter the score. The program stays open after each result so you can enter all 6 matches one after another without going back to the menu. A Go Back option is always available. If you type letters instead of numbers for a score the program shows an error and stays open. Goals above 99 are also rejected.

3. Simulate Group Results

Two options: simulate one specific group or simulate ALL remaining groups at once. Random but realistic scores are generated weighted towards low-scoring football results. If a group is already fully played the program tells you so.

4. View Group Standings

Shows the full standings table for any group. Includes position, games played, wins, draws, losses, goals for, goals against, goal difference and points. Shows how many of 6 matches have been played so far. Once all 6 games are played the top 2 are marked as QUALIFIED (automatic). A note reminds you that 3rd place may still qualify as one of the 8 best third-place teams.

5. View Match History

Shows all match results entered during the current session with group, teams and score.

6. Save data to file

Saves all data to worldcup_data.json. If a saved file already exists the program warns you and asks for confirmation before overwriting. Type yes (any capitalisation) to confirm or anything else to cancel.

7. Load previously saved data

Loads data from worldcup_data.json restoring group results, standings and knockout bracket. Clear error messages if the file does not exist or is corrupted.

8. View Qualified Teams (32 teams)

Available only once all 72 group stage matches are complete. Shows all 32 qualified teams: 12 group winners, 12 runners-up, 8 best third-place teams with stats, and the 4 eliminated third-place teams for comparison.

9. Play Knockout Stage

Available only once all group stage matches are complete. Asks you to choose between two modes:

- Mode 1 - Play match by match: Go through each match one at a time. For every match you can pick winner manually (1 or 2), simulate randomly (3), simulate the whole remaining round at once (4), or stop and go back to the main menu (5). The program flows automatically from round to round without returning to the menu between rounds.
- Mode 2 - Simulate all at once: The entire remaining knockout stage from current state to the Final is simulated instantly with random results and the World Cup Winner is announced immediately.

After the World Cup Winner is announced the program automatically shows a full tournament summary — final group stage rankings for all 12 groups and all knockout results from Round of 32 to the Final.

4. Requirements

Python 3.9 or higher. No additional libraries needed — only built-in modules (json, os, random).

Check Python version

```
python3 --version
```

You should see Python 3.9.x or higher.

Note: On Windows try python instead of python3 if the above does not work.

Install Python 3 on Mac

Step 1: Go to <https://www.python.org/downloads/>

Step 2: Click Download Python 3.x.x

Step 3: Open the .pkg file and follow the installer

Step 4: Confirm with `python3 --version` in Terminal

Install Python 3 on Windows

Step 1: Go to <https://www.python.org/downloads/>

Step 2: Click Download Python 3.x.x

Step 3: Open the .exe file

Step 4: IMPORTANT — tick Add Python to PATH before clicking Install Now. Without this the program will not run.

Step 5: Click Install Now

Step 6: Confirm with `python --version` in Command Prompt

5. How to Run the Program

Step 1: Download

Go to:

```
https://github.com/DylanObm/FIFA-World-Cup-2026-Group-Stage-Tracker-Phyton
```

Click `worldcup_tracker_01.py` and download it. Save it to your Desktop.

Step 2: Open a terminal

Mac: Command + Space, type Terminal, press Enter.

Windows: Windows key, type cmd, press Enter.

Step 3: Navigate to the file

```
cd Desktop
```

On Windows:

```
cd C:\Users\YourName\Desktop
```

Note: Replace YourName with your actual Windows username.

Step 4: Run

Mac:

```
python3 worldcup_tracker.py
```

Windows:

```
python worldcup_tracker.py
```

Step 5: Use the menu

Type a number between 1 and 10 and press Enter. Type 10 to exit.

6. Example of the Program Running

```
=====
FIFA WORLD CUP 2026 TRACKER
=====
Welcome! Track the full 2026 World Cup
=====
-----
MAIN MENU
-----
--- GROUP STAGE ---
1. View All Groups and Teams
2. Enter Match Result
3. Simulate Group Results
4. View Group Standings
5. View Match History
--- SAVE / LOAD ---
6. Save data to file
7. Load previously saved data
--- KNOCKOUT STAGE ---
8. View Qualified Teams (32 teams)
9. Play Knockout Stage
--- ---
10. Exit
-----
```

Entering a match result:

```
Choice: 2

Select a group:
1. Group A   2. Group B   3. Group C   ...

Enter group number: 1
```

Remaining matches in Group A:

1. Mexico vs South Africa
2. Korea Republic vs Czechia
3. Mexico vs Korea Republic
4. South Africa vs Czechia
5. Mexico vs Czechia
6. South Africa vs Korea Republic
7. Go back to main menu

Enter match number: 1

Enter goals for Mexico: 2

Enter goals for South Africa: 1

Result saved: Mexico 2 - 1 South Africa

Viewing standings after all matches:

GROUP A STANDINGS

Pos	Team	P	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	Pts	
1.	Mexico (automatic)	3	3	0	0	6	1	+5	9	>> QUALIFIED
2.	Korea Republic (automatic)	3	1	1	1	3	3	0	4	>> QUALIFIED
3.	Czechia	3	1	1	1	3	4	-1	4	
4.	South Africa	3	0	0	3	2	6	-4	0	